cognitive functioning and improves memory and mood. Carbohydrates and fats provide energy for growth and physical activity.

### Protein

Protein builds, maintains and repairs body tissue. It is especially important for growth. It's important that parents encourage children to eat two to three servings of protein daily. Good sources of protein for children include meat, fish, poultry, milk and other dairy products.

### Essential fatty acids

Deficiency of essential fatty acids may have a negative impact on school performance




**Fig.3.5 Role of Omega-3's in the Body**

### Minerals

Calcium is important in building strong bones and teeth. Bone density suffers when calcium needs are not met during childhood years. Osteoporosis, a disease associated with the softening of the bones affects a significant proportion of adults. This begins in childhood if diets do not provide adequate calcium-rich foods. Milk and dairy products and some dark green, leafy vegetables are good sources of calcium.

Children need iron because of rapidly expanding blood volume during growth. Meats, fish, poultry, and enriched breads and cereals are the best sources of dietary iron.

### Vitamins

A child needs vitamins for the body to function properly and to boost the immune system.




A variety of fruits and vegetables of different colours should be added in the child's food. Vitamin A is essential for vision and a deficiency of the same can lead to night blindness (difficulty in seeing in night). Dark green leafy vegetables, yellow, orange coloured vegetables and fruits such as carrots, papaya, mangoes are good sources of Vitamin A.

Vitamin D helps in bone growth and development and it is essential for absorption of calcium. Children get most of their Vitamin D from sunlight and a small amount from some food items like fish oils, fatty fish, mushrooms, cheese and egg yolks.

## 3.2.2 Snacking in school-aged children

During the primary school years, a greater proportion of meals may be eaten away from home in the school setting. Most of these snacks consumed are high fat foods. Snacks may contribute up to a significant proportion of total daily energy and nutrient needs of the school child. Salty snacks, such as packets of crisps or chips, may be of poor value as they give few nutrients.

Children who are both physically active and growing need to refuel periodically



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